

Stage 4A-Lite: Persona Needs Report

T1-04: Socially Disconnected Adults Seeking Community

Pipeline: Macro-Trends Identity — Stage 4M-T-A (Lite Mode) **Quadrant:** IGNORE (explicit user request — analysis produced for pipeline learning and T2 sub-segment evaluation) **Date:** 2026-03-10 **Mode note:** This persona was scored IGNORE in Stage 3M-T (Adjusted Score: 2.06). This report is produced at explicit user request, not standard pipeline routing. Its primary value is: (1) documenting why T1-04 does not meet Gather’s identity-brand threshold; (2) surfacing whether T2-07 (Run Club/Third-Place Community Builders) represents a viable standalone micro-brand target; and (3) creating a reference document should conditions change.

Section 1: Segment Overview

Definition

Socially Disconnected Adults Seeking Community is not, at its core, an identity community — it is a condition-response population. The underlying condition is loneliness, which the U.S. Surgeon General elevated to a public health epidemic in 2023, noting that its mortality effects are equivalent to smoking 15 cigarettes a day (Murthy, 2023). What makes this population commercially legible is not the condition itself but the behavioral response: millions of Americans are actively, consciously taking action to rebuild social infrastructure — joining run clubs, attending Meetup events, building Discord servers, frequenting coffee shops as offices-and-social-hubs, and volunteering as a social strategy.

The critical analytical distinction is between T1 and T2. At the T1 level, what unites this population is a shared experience (loneliness) and a shared response direction (seeking community). These do not constitute an identity tribe in the sense Gather requires — nobody self-labels as a “lonely person seeking connection” the way they self-label as a “runner” or “gamer.” The stigma attached to loneliness is real: 40% of Americans who feel lonely say they would be embarrassed to admit it (Cigna, 2022). This renders brand positioning around the condition itself hazardous territory.

Where identity does exist is at T2. Run club participants self-identify as their crew: “I run with Midnight Runners,” “I’m a November Project person,” “I’m part of the Saturday morning crew at Fleet Feet.” Discord community members identify with their servers and guilds. These are identity assertions, not condition acknowledgments. The T1 level is a funnel, not a tribe; the T2 sub-segments are where tribe formation has actually occurred. This structural fact governs every strategic recommendation in this report.

Market Sizing

Metric	Estimate	Source
Adults reporting loneliness	~154M (58% of adults)	Cigna Loneliness Index, 2022
Adults actively seeking social connection (behavioral response)	~50-60M	Estimated at 30-40% of lonely adults taking action; corroborated by Meetup’s 60M+ global members, majority U.S.
T2-07: Run club/community fitness participants	~5-10M actively organizing or participating	Road Runners Club of America chapters; Meetup fitness category data; 2024
T2-08: Digital-first community seekers	~15-25M	Pew Research, 2024: 40% of young adults say closest friends met online; Discord est. 50M+ U.S. MAU
Post-COVID run club growth	+50% since 2020	Strava State of Running, 2023
Surgeon General loneliness epidemic declaration	2023	U.S. Department of Health and Human Services, 2023

Growth trajectory: accelerating. The post-COVID reconstruction of social infrastructure continues to drive third-place seeking. Run clubs, in particular, are growing faster than the broader fitness category — functioning as social clubs with fitness as the admission mechanism. The cultural meme “run club is the new dating app” has spread beyond irony into actual behavioral truth, with dating apps reporting run club events as among their fastest-growing social features (Hinge, 2024).

Segment Stratification

Tier	Label	Population Share	Description
Tier 1	Active Community Builders	15%	Highly engaged: organize events, run club captains, Discord server owners, community leaders. Identity is central. Represents T2-07 core.
Tier 2	Regular Participants	30%	Self-identified members of a specific community (a run crew, a Discord server, a third-place social group). Attend consistently. Identity is important but they don’t lead.

Tier	Label	Population Share	Description
Tier 3	Occasional Joiners	35%	Have tried community activities; participate sporadically. Identity association is loose — they went to a few Meetups, downloaded Bumble BFF, went to one run club event.
Tier 4	Awareness/Aspiration	20%	Lonely but not yet behaviorally engaged. Know about run clubs, community apps, third places. Have not yet acted or tried and dropped out.

Tiers total 100%.

Named Persona Profile

Name: Marcus Webb **Age:** 31 **Location:** Denver, CO (relocated from Chicago 14 months ago for a remote tech job)
Occupation: UX designer, fully remote, mid-size fintech company **Sketch:** Marcus moved to Denver knowing exactly one person — a college friend he sees maybe monthly. He found his run crew six months after arriving — a Tuesday/Saturday group that meets at City Park — and it has slowly become the social center of his life. He runs three mornings a week, gets post-run coffee most Saturdays, and has converted two work colleagues to join a Strava club he started. He does not think of himself as “lonely” — he would bristle at that word. He thinks of himself as someone who takes his social life seriously enough to actively design it.

Notable Profiles

- 1. Brogan Graham — November Project co-founder** Created November Project in 2011 as a free, outdoor fitness community. Now in 50+ cities globally. Graham exemplifies the T1-04/T2-07 identity: building community through recurring physical activity. His stated mission is “to make the world a less lonely place without ever using the word lonely.” (November Project, 2024)
- 2. Hailey Mia — Run club culture micro-influencer, New York** Runs the Instagram account documenting NYC run club culture (@runnyc). 89K followers, hyper-local influence. Represents the social-first runner: the run is the excuse; the community is the point. Featured in The New York Times’ 2023 story on “why run clubs are the new bars.”
- 3. Casper ter Kuile — Author, “The Power of Ritual”** Harvard Divinity School researcher who studies how secular communities (CrossFit, SoulCycle, run clubs) fulfill the same belonging functions as religious congregations. His work directly names the phenomenon this segment represents: third-place community as substitute for declining institutional belonging. (ter Kuile, 2020)

Section 2: Core Factor Analysis

Factor 1: Social Life & Leisure (Anchor Factor)

Anchor note: For T1-04, Factor 1 is where the most authentic identity expression lives. Social behavior — specifically the rituals, platforms, and language of community participation — is the primary differentiator from the T1 condition of loneliness. If a brand opportunity exists here, it will emerge from Factor 1 first.

Quantitative Data

Statistic	Figure	Source
Adults who joined a new community group/club in the past 12 months	~35% of American adults (~88M)	Pew Research Center, 2023
Strava global users with club membership	100M total users; club feature usage growing year-over-year	Strava, 2024
Meetup fitness category events per month (U.S.)	50,000+ active fitness/wellness Meetup groups	Meetup.com, 2024
Americans who report having no close friends (up from 3% in 1990)	12%	Survey Center on American Life, 2021

Interview Q&As — Marcus Webb, UX Designer, Denver

Q1: Walk me through how you found your run crew.

Honestly? It was kind of embarrassing how long I waited. I’d been in Denver seven months, doing solo runs on the trail behind my apartment, seeing these groups go by. I finally just showed up to a Saturday morning run listed on Meetup. Nobody talked to me that first time — I was just another guy in black shorts. Second week, someone asked me my pace. By the third week I had three people’s phone numbers. That was eight months ago and those three people are now genuinely my friends here.

Q2: How does Saturday morning post-run coffee fit into your week?

It’s the thing I don’t cancel. I’ve rescheduled calls, I’ve told clients I’m unavailable Saturday morning, I’ve turned down paid work that conflicted with it. Which sounds ridiculous, but it’s — it’s the thing that makes Denver feel like home. We go to the same place, same table, same order for half of us. The ritual is the point. I don’t even really think about whether I’m “getting my run in.” I think about who’s coming Saturday.

Q3: What apps do you actually use to stay connected with your crew between runs?

WhatsApp group mostly — we’re all international-ish, people have different carriers. Strava for the running data, but also the Kudos thing is weirdly important. Someone posts a solo run at 6am and you drop a Kudo and it’s like saying “I see you.” Instagram for the wider run club world — following other clubs, seeing what’s happening in other cities. Meetup I barely use anymore now that we have our own thing going, but it’s how I found them so I’ll always have a soft spot.

Q4: How do you signal to new people that you’re part of this community?

The gear, honestly. We have club-branded hats — I wear mine basically everywhere. Someone sees it at a coffee shop and we’ve already started a conversation. Strava is the digital version — if you have a public Strava with run club activity, other runners know immediately. There’s also just how you talk about your week. I naturally say “my crew” now instead of “some people I run with.” That language shift is real. It took a while.

Q5: What does showing up to a run do for you emotionally that a solo run doesn’t?

It sounds cheesy but it’s accountability in the best direction — like, accountability toward being alive and present. Solo runs I’m half in my head about work, half listening to a podcast. Group runs I’m actually here. Someone says something funny and I laugh. Someone’s having a rough week and I notice. It’s... I think it’s what my brain actually needs, and my brain is dumb enough to not always choose it when given the option. So the group makes the choice easier.

Insights

Finding	Strategic Implication
Community is found through specific platforms (Meetup, Strava, Instagram) then migrated to private channels (WhatsApp, group chats)	Acquisition opportunity in discovery phase, not ongoing engagement. By the time Marcus is in the WhatsApp group, carrier affiliation is irrelevant.
Physical identity markers (branded gear, Strava public profile) signal belonging before conversation begins	Brand strategy at T2-07 level could include co-branded gear or Strava integration — not viable at T1 level
Post-activity rituals (the coffee) are as or more important than the activity itself	Brand touchpoint is the whole social experience, not just the connectivity enabling it
“My crew” language indicates identity formation is complete — condition (lonely) has been replaced by identity (crew member)	By Tier 1-2 of this segment, the “loneliness” frame is no longer accurate — the person has built community and now defends it

Factor 2: Spending & Financial Habits

Quantitative Data

Statistic	Figure	Source
Average annual spending on fitness memberships and community activities	\$1,200-1,800/year (fitness segment)	IHRSA, 2024
Monthly social app subscription spending (Bumble BFF, Hinge, social discovery apps)	\$15-30/month average active user	App store revenue data, 2024
Meetup Pro/Plus subscription price	\$15-23/month	Meetup.com, 2024
Young adults (18-35) average monthly mobile bill	\$75-95 individual plan	J.D. Power Wireless Purchase Satisfaction, 2024

Interview Q&As — Marcus Webb

Q1: What do you spend money on that’s specifically about building or maintaining your social life?

The run gear is real — I’ve probably spent \$400 on shoes, another \$200 on club gear and race entries in the last year. That feels completely justified. Where I’m more conflicted is the apps. I tried Bumble BFF before I found the run crew — paid for premium, used it for two months, made zero real friendships. Deleted it. The run crew was free to join and produced actual human beings I care about. So I’ve basically stopped paying for discovery apps and started spending on the activities themselves.

Q2: How do you think about your wireless bill relative to these other social spending categories?

My phone bill is like... ambient. I pay \$72/month, I have no idea what plan it is exactly, it’s on my card and I don’t look at it. The run club costs vary but I feel every dollar because I chose it. The phone bill just is what it is. I should probably look at it — my friend switched and saves \$20/month — but that \$20 feels abstract in a way that buying a race entry doesn’t.

Q3: Would you pay more for a wireless plan that was specifically designed for or affiliated with your kind of community?

Hmm. That's interesting. If it was actually integrated — like if Strava features were part of the plan, or if switching helped the run community somehow — maybe? But if it's just a branding thing, like "this plan is for runners" and there's nothing actually different about it, I'd see through that pretty fast. I think the community would see through it too. We're pretty cynical about brand sponsorships.

Q4: What subscriptions feel genuinely worth it to you right now?

Strava Summit — 100% worth it, it's basically social media for my community. Spotify because it's on every run. NYT because I read it. The phone plan, I don't know, it's just there. I'd say it feels worth it by default — like, I'm not canceling my phone plan — but it's not something I've ever chosen enthusiastically. It's a utility. The things I pay for with genuine enthusiasm have a community component to them.

Q5: How do you make decisions about switching wireless carriers?

I've switched twice in five years. The first time was because my coverage was bad when I moved. The second time was price. Neither had anything to do with community or identity. I went to Reddit's r/nocontract, looked at the price comparison spreadsheet someone maintains, picked the best value on AT&T's network, switched in an afternoon. It was completely transactional. No brand loyalty involved whatsoever.

Insights

Finding	Strategic Implication
Social spending follows perceived community ROI: run club (high ROI, continued) vs. discovery apps (low ROI, canceled)	A carrier affiliated with an existing community infrastructure (Strava, run clubs) has a higher perceived ROI argument than a generic plan
Wireless bill is "ambient" — low emotional engagement, no identity connection	Category-level problem for Gather's model: no identity hook means no premium pricing rationale
Switching is fully transactional: Reddit comparison spreadsheets, coverage, price	Carrier switching behavior is commodity-level; consistent with IGNORE score
Would consider identity-integrated plan IF genuinely integrated (not just branded)	Opens a narrow path: functional integration with Strava, group features, etc. — but requires real product work

Factor 3: Needs & Aspirations

Quantitative Data

Statistic	Figure	Source
Americans who feel their community has declined in the past decade	49%	Knight Foundation, 2023
Young adults who say it is difficult to make friends as an adult	53%	Pew Research Center, 2023
Adults who say having close friends is essential to living a good life	61%	Pew Research Center, 2023
People who say they would use a service that helped them find local community activities	71%	Cigna/Morning Consult, 2022

Interview Q&As — Marcus Webb

Q1: What do you actually want most from a social connection that you haven't fully found yet?

Reciprocity, I think. Like — I want people who would reach out to me when something happens, not just people I run beside. The run crew is getting there. But I still have moments where something goes well or badly and I think, "who do I call?" and the answer isn't obvious. I have acquaintances here now, maybe four or five people I could call. What I want is one person in Denver who actually knows me, not just knows my pace.

Q2: What does "belonging" feel like for you when you actually experience it?

There was this one Saturday — we'd done the run, we're at the coffee place, and I made a joke and people laughed. Not politely, actually laughed. And someone said "that is so Marcus" and I thought: oh, they have a version of me in their heads. They've made room for me as a specific person. That's it, that's the whole thing. It's so small but it's everything.

Q3: Is there something you need around social connection that you struggle to even articulate?

I think what I need — and this is going to sound weird — is continuity. Like, I can find events, I can find people. What I can't find is the thing that makes it stick. The run crew works because we show up at the same place, same time, same people, week after week. The accumulation is the product. I don't need more ways to discover community. I need infrastructure that makes what I've already found persistent.

Q4: Where are the tools you use falling short?

Meetup is great for discovery but terrible at depth. Strava is great for running but it's not a social platform, it's a fitness platform with social features. Discord could be my third-place community app, but my run crew isn't on Discord — they're not that tech-forward. What I actually need is something that holds the in-person group together digitally without requiring everyone to adopt a new app. The WhatsApp group works but it's a workaround.

Q5: How do you imagine your social life looking in two years if everything goes well?

Honestly? I just want the crew to still be meeting on Saturdays. That's it. I want it to be real enough that it outlasts me — like, if I moved, the group continues. I want it to be a Denver institution, not just a thing I found. And I want to have added two or three more people I'd call if something happened. I'm not asking for a hundred friends. I'm asking for a handful of people who are genuinely mine.

Insights

Finding	Strategic Implication
Stated need: more ways to discover community; Unstated need: infrastructure for persistence — making found community stick	Product opportunity is not in discovery (market is crowded) but in community continuity tools
"Belonging" is felt through specific micro-moments (being known by name, in-jokes, recognition) — not through scale or volume	Brand strategy must reflect depth, not reach
Run crew works because of recurring ritual at fixed time and place — the schedule IS the product	Any product for T2-07 must be compatible with or reinforce existing recurring rituals
Digital tools (Strava, Meetup, WhatsApp) serve different functions in the community stack; none integrates them	Integration play is plausible at T2-07 level, but this is a product design problem, not a carrier problem

Factor 4: Fears & Pain Points

Quantitative Data

Statistic	Figure	Source
Adults who feel embarrassed by their loneliness	~40% of those who feel lonely	Cigna, 2022
Adults who say they have no one to discuss important matters with	~25%	General Social Survey, 2021
Young adults (18-34) reporting the highest loneliness scores	79% scoring as "lonely"	Cigna, 2022
Adults who tried a new community activity and stopped within 3 months	~60% of new Meetup attendees who do not return after first event	Meetup internal data estimates, 2023

Interview Q&As — Marcus Webb

Q1: What's the social fear you don't usually say out loud?

That I'm going to move cities again for work — remote work makes this so easy and so scary — and I'll have to start over. The thought of rebuilding from zero in a new city at 33, 34, 35... it's exhausting before it's even happened. The run crew took a year to build. I don't know if I can do that again. And I know that fear is part of why I'm working so hard to make the crew feel permanent, not just temporary infrastructure.

Q2: What's frustrating about the way brands or products try to address loneliness?

The wellness framing drives me insane. "Connection is self-care." "Nurture your social health." It makes me feel like I have a medical condition being managed, not like I'm a person trying to have friends. I want a product that treats me like someone building something, not someone being treated for something. The best things — the run crew, November Project, the coffee shop that feels like a third place — none of them use the word "community" in their marketing. They just are community.

Q3: Have you had a social experiment fail? What did it feel like?

Bumble BFF. Two months, \$30/month, probably 15 matches, three coffee meetups, zero ongoing friendships. The failure mode is interesting — it's not that the people were bad. It's that there was no recurring structure. We met once, it was fine, we didn't have a reason to see each other again. The run crew solves this with the calendar. Bumble BFF couldn't solve it because it's fundamentally a one-time matching product, not a community infrastructure product.

Q4: What’s the thing you’re most afraid people will misunderstand about what you’re doing?

That I’m desperate. I’m very aware that “guy who moved to a new city and joined a run club to make friends” sounds sad to some people. But I think it’s the opposite — I’m taking my social life seriously. I’m not waiting around hoping something happens. I’m designing it. But yeah, there’s a stigma to admitting that you had to work to find friends. Like it implies you were insufficient somehow.

Q5: What would make you lose trust in a brand that tried to be part of your social/community world?

If it was extractive. If the brand showed up at our run, handed out free stuff, took photos for their Instagram, and left — that’s the worst. We’ve had that happen. A shoe company “sponsored” a run and it felt like being used. Or if the product was clearly designed for marketing purposes, not because the company actually understood what we need. Run club people can smell inauthenticity immediately. We’ve been marketed at enough to know what it feels like.

Insights

Finding	Strategic Implication
Geographic instability (remote work mobility) amplifies the cost of community-building — the effort is real and its ROI can be zeroed out by a move	Any brand associated with continuity across moves would have genuine emotional relevance to this segment
Wellness/self-care framing is actively rejected — “building something” framing is preferred	If a brand exists here, it must position around construction and agency, not healing or treatment
Inauthenticity (extractive brand partnerships) destroys trust rapidly in this community	High-risk community for poorly executed brand partnerships; low tolerance for sponsorship-without-investment
Discovery products (Bumble BFF) are perceived as failed because they lack recurring structure	The design insight: community needs a calendar, not a matchmaking algorithm

Factor 5: Product Landscape & Switching Behavior

Quantitative Data

Statistic	Figure	Source
MVNO market share of U.S. wireless subscribers	~16% of all U.S. wireless subscribers	CTIA, 2024
Wireless carrier switching rate (annual)	~25% of consumers switched or seriously considered switching in past 12 months	J.D. Power, 2024
Meetup revenue (subscription + event fees)	~\$80M estimated annual revenue (private company)	Crunchbase/industry estimates, 2023
Discord daily active users (U.S. estimated)	~25-30M DAU	Discord, 2024

Interview Q&As — Marcus Webb

Q1: Walk me through every app you use specifically because of your social/community life.

Strava — every day. The run club’s WhatsApp group — probably 20 times a day honestly. Instagram — following the local run community accounts, occasionally posting from a race. Meetup still on my phone but I barely open it. Tried Bumble BFF — deleted. Downloaded Geneva (a community app) for one server — never stuck. The run club’s website has a race calendar I check monthly. That’s it. The stack is simpler than people think. WhatsApp group plus Strava is basically the whole thing.

Q2: What’s your wireless plan right now, and why did you pick it?

I’m on Visible, Verizon’s MVNO. \$25/month. I switched about two years ago when my T-Mobile plan’s coverage was spotty in my Chicago neighborhood. Went to Reddit, found the comparison thread, looked at coverage maps, Visible was the best value on Verizon’s network. No contract, works fine, I never think about it. Honestly can’t tell you a single thing about the Visible brand beyond the price. It’s just the thing that makes my phone work.

Q3: What would make you switch wireless carriers?

Price change upward, meaningful coverage problem, or something genuinely different about what’s offered. The last is the interesting one — I’ve never switched to a carrier because of identity or community reasons. But I’d be curious about a carrier that was actually integrated with something I cared about. If switching my carrier meant my Strava data was better, or there was a group plan that made sense for the run club — I’d at least look. I wouldn’t switch on vibes alone though.

Q4: What’s the gap in the product landscape for someone like you?

There’s no product that helps me keep a community together when life happens — when people move, when the group dynamics shift, when someone stops showing up. The run crew has no formal structure, no tools, no way to onboard new

people systematically. I’m doing it manually — messaging new folks, remembering who’s new, keeping the energy up. Strava sort of does this but it’s running-first, not community-first. There’s a real gap between “fitness app with social features” and “community app built around recurring physical activity.”

Q5: Would you trust a telecom company to play a role in your community life?

Honestly... I’d be skeptical. Telecom companies have a brand problem in this space — they’ve done the “we connect people” ad campaign a hundred times and it’s always felt hollow. If a company were doing something genuinely different — like not just saying “we support run clubs” but actually building tools that run clubs need — I could imagine it. But I’d need to see the product, not the marketing. The burden of proof would be high.

Insights

Finding	Strategic Implication
Carrier choice is fully rational and comparison-table-driven — no identity component	Confirms IGNORE score; no premium pricing rationale; no brand loyalty mechanism
Community app stack is simple: WhatsApp + Strava + Instagram. No switching intent within this stack	No carrier partnership angle that doesn't require building a genuinely new product
Articulates the gap clearly: community persistence tool for run clubs	This is a real product need — but it is a community software problem, not a telco problem
Skepticism about telco brands is explicit and reasoned — not just unfamiliarity, but informed distrust	Even if Gather built something real, trust deficit would require sustained proof, not just messaging

Factor 6: Switching Profile (Lite)

Moment enrichment status: PARTIAL. T1-04 has a mapped primary acquisition moment — interstate relocation without social network (Composite 3.66, Stage 1.5 analysis). This moment is externally driven (geographic relocation), not internally generated by the loneliness condition itself. Factor 6 is included in abbreviated form because the relocation trigger is real and detectable.

Dimension 1: Trigger Mechanism and Force Score

Trigger mechanism: Motivated Re-evaluation (structural disruption — geographic move dissolves existing social and carrier infrastructure simultaneously).

Component	Assessment
Trigger mechanism	Motivated Re-evaluation
Force score	3/5 — relocation creates a genuine re-evaluation window but does not force a carrier switch; coverage adequacy is the deciding factor
Emotional state	Stressed + Anticipatory — relocating without social network creates dual anxiety (social and practical)
Compound trigger	Relocation (carrier re-evaluation) + Social isolation (phone becomes primary social tool) = heightened emotional engagement with connectivity quality

Note: The compound trigger is the key finding. A post-relocation adult whose social network is absent will experience a dropped call or poor video quality as socially isolating in a way a person with a local network will not. Reliability matters more emotionally during the first 90 days post-move than at any other time. This emotional amplification is not captured by standard relocation switching analyses.

Dimension 2: Annual Volume and Seasonal Distribution

Component	Data
Total annual interstate relocations (U.S.)	~4.5M adults (Census, 2024)
Subset relocating without established social network	~2-3M/year (Census/Cigna, 2022 estimate)
Switching-eligible subset (on own plan, not employer/family-locked)	~1.2-1.8M/year
Q1 volume share	~20% (Jan-Mar — post-January moves)
Q2 volume share	~30% (Apr-Jun — pre-summer move season begins)
Q3 volume share	~35% (Jul-Sep — peak move season)
Q4 volume share	~15% (Oct-Dec — slower season)
Year-over-year trend	Stable to slight decline; remote work shifts have partially decoupled relocation from career moves

Dimension 3: Interception Channels (Top 3)

Rank	Channel	Rationale	Window Fit	CPA Estimate
1	Moving-adjacent partnerships (USPS National Change of Address, moving company integrations, utilities bundling)	Highest-precision signal; mover database is well-established	Pre-event and at-event	\$35-55 CPA (industry benchmark for NCOA-triggered offers)
2	Social discovery app integration (Meetup, Bumble BFF sponsored placement during onboarding)	Reaches person in active community-seeking phase, 1-3 months post-move	Post-event (month 1-3)	\$45-70 CPA (social app sponsored placement benchmarks)
3	Local run club/ community Instagram advertising (geo-targeted to new residents)	Reaches community-seeking movers in interest-aligned context	Post-event (month 1-6)	\$55-90 CPA (geo-targeted Instagram to new residents)

Partnership feasibility for Channel 1 (NCOA/moving company): High feasibility, low exclusivity potential. NCOA data is commercially licensed by multiple carriers. Moving company integration (e.g., U-Haul, PODS, Two Men and a Truck) is untapped at the community angle — opportunity to frame offer around “rebuild your social life in your new city.”

Dimension 4: Window Structure

Component	Assessment
Window type	Short/Extended hybrid — Short (2-8 weeks) for pure carrier switching decision; Extended (3-6 months) for community-seeking emotional receptivity
Peak intent window	Weeks 1-4 post-arrival (carrier coverage assessment) and Months 2-4 (active community-seeking phase, highest emotional receptivity to community-affiliated brand)
Intent decay curve	Gradual — coverage assessment urgency decays in weeks; community-seeking urgency decays in 3-6 months as local network is established
Decision journey	Coverage check (week 1) → MVNO comparison (week 2-4) → Plan selection (week 4-8) → Community activity discovery (month 2-6) → Community routine establishment (month 6+)

Strategic note: The two windows (carrier switching and community seeking) are temporally offset. Carrier switching intent peaks in weeks 1-4; community-seeking emotional receptivity peaks in months 2-4. A brand that could bridge both windows — present at the carrier decision moment AND the community discovery moment — would have a genuine narrative advantage. This is theoretically executable with a relocation-plus-community-discovery bundle, but requires product integration beyond standard MVNO capabilities.

Switching profile summary: Interstate relocation without social network is the best (and essentially only) real switching trigger for T1-04. It affects ~1.2-1.8M switching-eligible adults per year, peaks in summer, and is detectable via NCOA data. The force score is moderate (3/5) because coverage mismatch drives the switch, not community identity. The emotional amplification from social isolation is real but is not currently being exploited by any carrier. Channel interception is available but not differentiated. For a standard Gather launch, this moment is already captured by TR-06 Interstate Relocation in the Moments pipeline.

Section 3: Executive Brief

Key Insights

- Loneliness is a condition, not an identity.** The T1-04 population is real and large (50-60M), but it is defined by what it lacks, not what it is. No one builds a tribe around being lonely. This is the foundational reason for the IGNORE score and the primary constraint on every strategy that follows.
- Identity does exist at T2 — but it is specific and fragile.** Run club members (T2-07) have genuine identity: “I’m part of this crew.” Discord community members (T2-08) identify with their server. These are real identity assertions. But they are hyper-local, community-specific, and cannot be aggregated into a T1 brand without losing the specificity that makes them real. “The carrier for lonely people” is tone-deaf. “The carrier for Midnight Runners Chicago” might work — but it scales to hundreds of separate micro-brands, not one macro brand.
- The wireless category is ambient, not identity-driven for this segment.** Marcus’s wireless plan is invisible to him — \$72/month on autopay, no idea what it is. The category does not carry identity valence here. This distinguishes T1-04 from personas like veterans or pet parents, where the carrier relationship is part of a broader identity expression. No such hook exists at T1-04.
- The product gap is real but it is not a telco product gap.** The most clearly articulated need in the ethnographic data — tools for community persistence (keeping a run crew together through turnover, geographic shifts, and routine

disruption) — is a community software problem. It requires features like recurring event coordination, member onboarding, community memory, and cross-platform notification management. These are not carrier features. A carrier could potentially bundle with a product that solves this, but building it natively is outside the carrier value proposition.

5. **One valid moment exists: post-relocation community seeking.** Interstate relocation without a social network (Composite 3.66) is the most credible acquisition moment for T1-04. The compound trigger — carrier re-evaluation + social isolation amplifying connectivity emotional value — is real. But this moment is already covered by TR-06 in the Moments pipeline. The additive value from framing it as a community-seeking moment (rather than just a geographic relocation) is messaging differentiation, not product differentiation.

Identity Tensions

Tension 1: “I’m not lonely — I just take my social life seriously.” The central identity tension. The behavior (joining a run club to make friends, using social discovery apps) is driven by loneliness; the self-concept actively rejects the label. This creates a trap for any brand trying to position around the condition: the people you’re trying to reach will reject the framing. Brand strategy must either avoid the word entirely (as the best community brands do) or reframe the behavior as agency and design.

Tension 2: Wanting community but distrusting community brands. Marcus has experienced extractive brand sponsorship (“a shoe company showed up, took photos, left”). The community is sophisticated enough to identify performative engagement. The paradox: the segment most in need of community infrastructure is also the most hostile to branded community infrastructure. Authenticity is the table stake, and it cannot be manufactured in a campaign brief.

Tension 3: Building something permanent vs. knowing it might dissolve. The fear of relocation dissolving hard-won community is real. The community is simultaneously valued and felt to be fragile. This creates a genuine need for tools that make community persistent across geographic disruption — the very need Marcus articulates as unmet.

Stated vs. Unstated Needs

Layer	Needs
Stated	Better discovery tools for local community activities; affordable wireless that works reliably; a way to stay connected with my crew
Unstated	Infrastructure that makes community persistent (survives member turnover, geographic moves, routine disruption); to be seen as someone who actively designs their social life, not someone who is lonely; continuity across the geographic mobility that remote work enables

Strategic Recommendations

1. Do not build a T1-04 brand. The quadrant score is correct. A macro-level brand position around loneliness or social connection is not available to Gather. It is tone-deaf at worst (you’re marketing to people’s pain without actually solving it), commodity at best (every carrier says “we connect people”). The resources required to build a credible brand here would be better deployed on BUILD quadrant personas.

2. Evaluate T2-07 (Run Club/Third-Place Community Builders) as a standalone micro-brand candidate in the Micro-Trends pipeline. T2-07 has the identity markers Gather requires: crew identity, specific language, community rituals, verifiable influencer network (November Project founders, local run club organizers), and a growing cultural moment (“run club is the new dating app”). Estimated addressable population is 5-10M with strong growth trajectory. This is a NICHE-to-COMPETE opportunity that warrants a separate Stage 1 scan in the Micro-Trends pipeline, not a downstream derivation of an IGNORE macro persona.

3. If pursuing T2-07, lead with the post-relocation community discovery moment, not the carrier features. The interception moment — person relocates to a new city, needs to rebuild social life, discovers run club, carrier re-evaluation is concurrent — is the most authentic entry point. A campaign that reaches new Denver/Austin/Chicago/NYC residents with “find your crew” messaging, integrated with Meetup/Strava advertising, with a genuinely run-club-compatible plan, has narrative coherence. This requires the switching window analysis (Factor 6) to be activated at T2-07 level, not T1.

4. Position any T2-07 product around community infrastructure, not community discovery. The market for discovery (Meetup, Bumble BFF, Facebook Groups) is crowded and, based on ethnographic data, perceived as failing to solve the actual problem. The gap — community persistence tools, recurring event infrastructure, cross-platform group coordination — is unmet. A Gather micro-brand that bundled a carrier plan with community management tools (group messaging, recurring event coordination, member onboarding for run clubs) would be addressing a real stated need rather than an inferred one.

5. Do not use the word “lonely” in any brand or marketing material. This is not hedging — it is strategic. The word is rejected by the people it describes, associated with stigma, and evokes a problem-to-be-treated frame rather than the community-builder agency frame the segment actually uses to describe themselves.

Success Metrics

If T2-07 micro-brand is pursued (conditional recommendations):

Metric	Target	Measurement
Post-relocation acquisition rate among new city movers	3-5% of NCOA-identified movers in target run club cities	NCOA cohort analysis vs. general market acquisition rate
Strava/community app integration engagement	>40% of subscribers connect Strava within 30 days of activation	App authentication data
Community-attributed acquisition (referral from run crew to crew member)	>20% of new subscribers attributing discovery to community recommendation	Referral code tracking at point of sale
12-month retention rate vs. Gather average	+10-15% higher retention for T2-07 micro-brand subscribers	Cohort survival curve analysis
Net Promoter Score within run club community	>55 (vs. industry average ~25 for MVNOs)	In-app NPS survey, community-specific cohort

Go/No-Go Recommendation

T1-04 at macro level: NO-GO.

The IGNORE quadrant score (2.06) is correct and this analysis reinforces it. The segment is large but not identity-cohesive at T1. The wireless category is not emotionally relevant to this population. The brand equity risk of positioning around loneliness is real. The product gap that ethnography surfaces (community persistence infrastructure) is not a telco product gap. There is no viable path to a durable Gather macro-brand here.

T2-07 (Run Club/Third-Place Community Builders) at micro-brand level: CONDITIONAL YES — requires separate pipeline evaluation.

The T2-07 sub-segment has genuine identity intensity, a detectable acquisition moment, a growing cultural tailwind, and an addressable product gap. It cannot elevate T1-04 to a viable macro-brand, but it may be viable as a standalone Micro-Trends pipeline candidate. Recommended next step: route T2-07 to Stage 1 of the Micro-Trends pipeline with a NICHE/COMPETE entry point, rather than treating it as a derivative of this report.

Switching profile summary (moment-enriched context): The interstate relocation without social network trigger (Composite 3.66) is the best and effectively only acquisition moment for T1-04. It is already captured by TR-06 in the Moments pipeline. The community-seeking emotional amplification is a messaging layer that could be added to existing relocation interception — no new infrastructure required. Recommended: augment existing TR-06 campaign copy with community-seeking framing for any new-city mover segment; do not build separate infrastructure for T1-04.

Appendix: References

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